

progress you are envious of and whom you have not forgiven for breaking your country into two. Also, knowing fully well that India would not pick a full-scale war because of your possession of nuclear weapons. War cries are being heard but with two nuclearised nations that is hardly an option. War is only a means to end and the end can never be mutual destruction. I am reminded of a quote of my favourite speech, John F. Kennedy's inaugural address in which he said: "So let us begin anew—remembering on both sides that civility is not a sign of weakness, and sincerity is always subject to proof. Let us never negotiate out of fear but never fear to negotiate." Perhaps that is how we have to deal with Pakistan.

So, what do we do? Give up hope on our failing leaders. No. We have the good fortune of being a democracy. Undoubtedly, it has its ills but public opinion is its lifeblood. For politicians, it is their oxygen. Since the Mumbai attack there has been a groundswell of public anger against their leaders. The people don't want to be taken for granted. They want action.

In the interest of getting action and building public opinion on a sustained basis, the India Today Group has pledged to use all its media platforms to keep this issue in the public consciousness till the Government delivers on its promises. For this, we have launched a movement titled 'Declare War on Terror' which is the subject of this special issue.

In this issue, we begin by looking inwards. Despite repeated warnings from many sources that India could expect a terrorist attack from the sea, all information tragically and criminally went unheeded leading to the events of Mumbai. We ask how can our security networks be better prepared, better equipped and better run. We look at our international options and how to tackle the thorny issue of Pakistan, which may include diplomatic or even military options. We ask whether we need an international coalition to fight our war and assess the political and economic impact of the Mumbai attacks. We have invited leading national and international columnists to assess India's options at this point in time and how we can learn from the experiences of other countries subjected to the scourge of modern terrorism.

As part of our movement, we ask you to sign a pledge and return it with your ideas of how best we can fight the war on terror. We will be calling on leading experts on security, geopolitics and law, and seeking their views on the subject. We will then formulate the best plan for the situation that is decisive, effective and time-bound, and take it up with the national leadership.



WE, THE PEOPLE OF INDIA,

DECLARE WAR ON TERROR TODAY.

We face the gravest threat as a nation.

We pledge to

FIGHT against those who kill the innocent

SUPPORT measures that ensure our safety

EXPOSE corruption and incompetence that endanger our security

DEFEAT the enemy by having zero tolerance of terror

ELIMINATE the forces which propagate hate

BE united in our resolve

TILL VICTORY IS OURS

To pledge, log on to www.indiatoday.in/war

Also, we will be starting a 'Declare War on Terror' forum under the aegis of our non-profit foundation CARE TODAY, which will carry on the movement even after the Mumbai terror attacks have vanished from the headlines. This forum will push for change in policy and law. It will study and present detailed proposals for upgradation of our anti-terror institutions. It will serve as a watchdog body to demand efficiency, governance and alertness from our civil administration. It will ensure that the heroes in this war are honoured. It will, through debate and discussion, try and build a national consensus on this issue. Above all, it will not allow the issue of terrorism to fade away from the public domain and the national agenda.

We ask you to join this fight along with us.

We believe that India can win this war against terrorism. Because we can. Because we must.

At the height of World War II, Winston Churchill talked of the imperatives of victory. Today his eloquent words apply to India too: "Victory at all costs, victory in spite of all terror, victory however long and hard the road may be; for without victory there is no survival." Let's lead our leaders. And stay angry.

(Aroon Purie)